LONDON, UNITED KINGDOM

The Courtauld Gallery: Masterpieces

Twenty works that make looking, reflection and unequal awareness part of the subject.



The barmaid stands close to the spectator, yet the mirror behind her makes that apparently direct encounter difficult to locate. In another painting, a watcher leans over a sleeping figure; in a landscape, travellers nearly disappear into the terrain they must cross. The Courtauld selection repeatedly changes who has access to a scene and how much they can know about it.

That question extends to the objects themselves. A drawing of the Colossus reconstructs a lost monument without becoming evidence of its original appearance. A study for a dance isolates movements rather than recording a complete performance. Looking requires attention to the kind of image in front of us as well as its subject.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/courtauld-gallery

The selection · 20

1. A Bar at the Folies-Bergère
   Édouard Manet · 1882
2. Nevermore
   Paul Gauguin · 1897
3. Self-Portrait with Bandaged Ear
   Vincent van Gogh · 1889
4. Young Woman Powdering Herself
   Georges Seurat · 1889-1890
5. Study for Le Chahut
   Georges Seurat · 1889-1890
6. Landscape with the Flight into Egypt
   Pieter Bruegel the Elder · 1563
7. The Dream of Human Life
   Michelangelo · 1533
8. The Conversion of Saint Paul
   Peter Paul Rubens · c. 1612
9. The Coronation of the Virgin
   Peter Paul Rubens · c. 1620
10. David Slaying Goliath
    Peter Paul Rubens · c. 1620
11. Landscape with an Imaginary View of Tivoli
    Claude Lorrain · 1642
12. Portrait of a Man
    Gerolamo Forabosco · c. 1650
13. Saint Lawrence
    Girolamo da Santacroce · c. 1520–1530
14. Saint Sebastian in a Rocky Landscape with Saints Jerome, Anthony Abbot and Christopher
    Marco Zoppo · c. 1475–1478
15. A Mandarin Drake
    Eugène Delacroix · c. 1825
16. Boats at Martigues
    Raoul Dufy · 1908
17. The Colossus of Rhodes
    Maarten van Heemskerck · 1570
18. Cupid and Psyche
    Joshua Reynolds · 1789
19. Holy Family with the Infant Saint John and Saint Elizabeth
    Benvenuto Tisi · 1520
20. Man Holding a Book
    Rogier van der Weyden · 1440-1449

01 / 20

A Bar at the Folies-Bergère

Édouard Manet

1882 · Canvas; paint medium not specified · The Courtauld Gallery



Édouard Manet. A Bar at the Folies-Bergère. Image credit: Édouard Manet; Source credit: Un bar aux Folies-Bergère d'E. Manet (Fondation Vuitton, Paris); Photograph: Jean-Pierre Dalbéra (https://www.flickr.com/people/72746018@N00), explicitly credited in the Commons file Author field.. CC BY 2.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.0). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · CC BY 2.0

The counter offers a close, apparently secure position in front of the barmaid. Her reflection, shifted to the right, unsettles it. The Courtauld identifies the sitter as Suzon, who posed in Manet's studio after he made on-site sketches. The finished picture is a constructed encounter, not a transparent snapshot of the music hall.

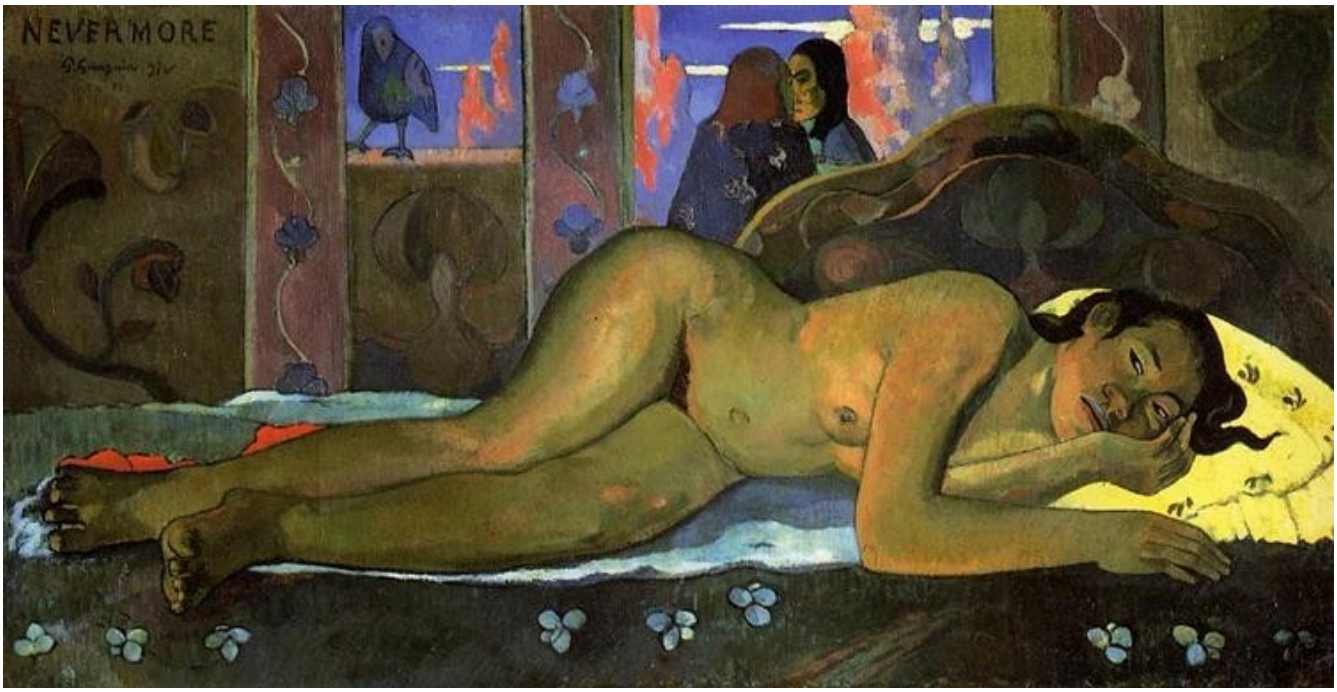
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P.1934.SC.234

02 / 20

Nevermore

Paul Gauguin

1897 · The Courtauld Gallery



Paul Gauguin. Nevermore. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The reclining woman turns her head toward a room containing other figures and a bird. The painted title adds another sign without settling the relations among them. Gauguin’s setting should not be read as straightforward documentation of Tahitian life. Its watchers and conversations belong to an image whose arrangement keeps their meaning uncertain.

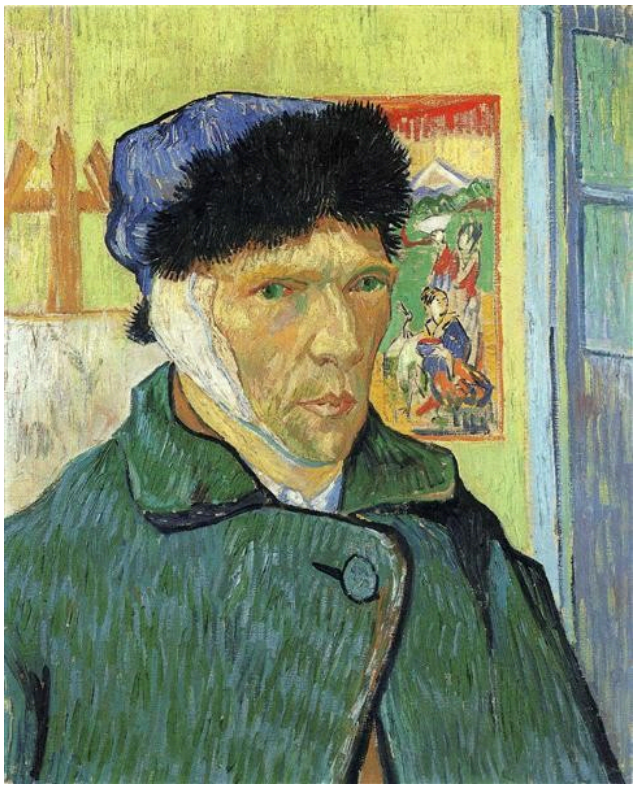
Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Self-Portrait with Bandaged Ear

Vincent van Gogh

1889 · The Courtauld Gallery



Vincent van Gogh. Self Portrait with Bandaged Ear. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The bandage is conspicuous, but it is not the portrait's only information. Coat, cap, studio setting and the print behind the figure remain present through firm contours and differentiated strokes. Van Gogh's injury belongs within a continuing act of representation. Biography can identify the condition without accounting for every pictorial choice.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Young Woman Powdering Herself

Georges Seurat

1889-1890 · The Courtauld Gallery



42. WOMAN POWDERING HERSELF. Probably 1889–1890. London, Courtauld Institute Galleries (Home House Trustees)

Georges Seurat. Young Woman Powdering Herself. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The powder puff brings the hand near the face and gives the seated pose a practical purpose. Rounded forms repeat through hair, arm, bodice and dressing table. Across them, divided marks of colour maintain their own surface. A private routine becomes recognisable through both an action and a carefully related arrangement of curves.

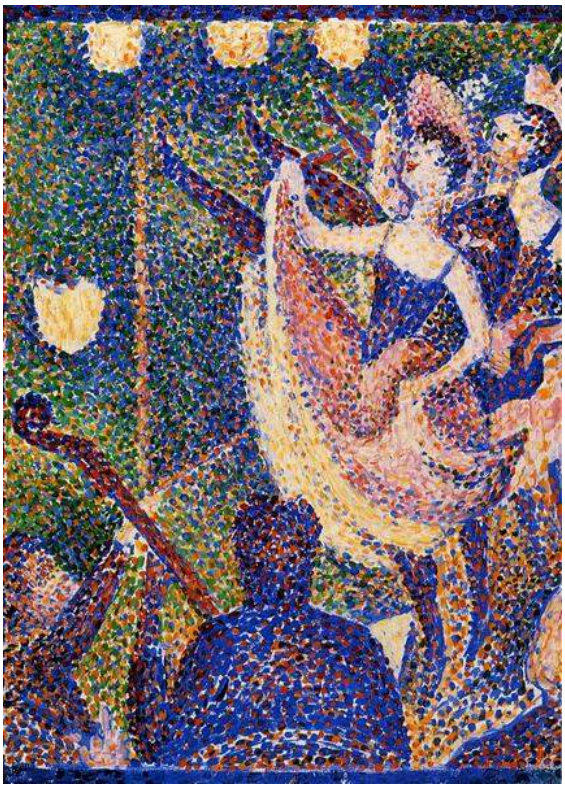
Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Study for Le Chahut

Georges Seurat

1889-1890 · The Courtauld Gallery



Georges Seurat. Study for The Chahut. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The raised leg and neighbouring curved form establish a dance through repeated directions. This is a study, so its narrow selection need not explain an entire performance. The marks test how coordinated movement can remain legible when the individual performer is reduced to a part within a larger pattern.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Landscape with the Flight into Egypt

Pieter Bruegel the Elder

1563 · Oil on panel · The Courtauld Gallery



Pieter Bruegel the Elder. Landscape with the Flight into Egypt. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pieter-bruegel-the-elder/landscape-with-the-flight-into-egypt-1563 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The travellers are small beside the river, mountains and settlements. Their route has to be found within a view that can first appear available simply as an extensive landscape. Once recognised, the group changes the scale of attention: this large world is also ground through which vulnerable people must make their way.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

The Dream of Human Life

Michelangelo

1533 · Chalk on paper · The Courtauld Gallery



The Dream of Human Life. WikiArt; Michelangelo. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The central nude has a solidity that the smaller surrounding scenes do not share. A winged figure approaches above, while masks and other images complicate the apparently self-contained body. The drawing brings the person into relation with roles and visions around him, without turning those relations into one continuous everyday setting.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

The Conversion of Saint Paul

Peter Paul Rubens

c. 1612 · The Courtauld Gallery



Peter Paul Rubens. Conversion of Saint Paul. Image credit: Peter Paul Rubens. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Riders and horses lose their coordinated movement as light enters the crowded scene. Falling bodies and opposed directions make conversion visible as an interruption of control. Rubens gives the event a physical consequence before every figure is distinguished: the group's previous order can no longer hold.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P.1978.PG.356

09 / 20

The Coronation of the Virgin

Peter Paul Rubens

c. 1620 · The Courtauld Gallery



Peter Paul Rubens. Coronation of the Virgin. Image credit: Peter Paul Rubens. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Mary's kneeling position remains identifiable amid clouds, angels and movement because larger areas of red, blue and pale colour separate the principal bodies. The arrangement directs attention upward without making every figure equally important. Ceremony depends on that hierarchy; otherwise the surrounding activity could overwhelm its central act.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P.1978.PG.363

10 / 20

David Slaying Goliath

Peter Paul Rubens

c. 1620 · The Courtauld Gallery



Peter Paul Rubens. David Slaying Goliath. Image credit: Peter Paul Rubens. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

David’s raised arm and bent body obtain leverage over the fallen giant. At this stage of the story, being smaller does not prevent him from controlling the encounter. The restricted browns concentrate attention on the bodies’ crossing directions, keeping the narrative close to the mechanics of one imminent blow.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P.1978.PG.366

11 / 20

Landscape with an Imaginary View of Tivoli

Claude Lorrain

1642 · The Courtauld Gallery



Claude Lorrain. Landscape with an Imaginary View of Tivoli. Image credit: Claude Lorrain. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The title allows the view to be imaginary without making it arbitrary. Bridge, hill, water and foreground shade occupy connected stages, with light giving access to the distance. Claude assembles a coherent place from these relations. Plausible space need not be mistaken for an exact report of topography.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P.1978.PG.64

12 / 20

Portrait of a Man

Gerolamo Forabosco

c. 1650 · The Courtauld Gallery



Gerolamo Forabosco. Portrait of a Man. Image credit: Gerolamo Forabosco; Art UK. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Girolamo_Forabosco_(c.1605-1679)_(attributed_to)_-_Portrait_of_a_Man_-_P.1947.LF.133_-_Courtauld_Gallery.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The fur-trimmed garment occupies an expansive area around a more firmly described face. A pale architectural opening provides a contrasting boundary, while the hand gives the lower part a point of contact. The sitter acquires substance through the relation between likeness and material, without needing an extensive collection of explanatory possessions.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P.1947.LF.133

13 / 20

Saint Lawrence

Girolamo da Santacroce

c. 1520–1530 · The Courtauld Gallery



Girolamo da Santacroce. Saint Lawrence. Image credit: Girolamo da Santacroce; Art UK. https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Girolamo_da_Santacroce_(1480-1485-1556)_-_Saint_Lawrence_-_P.1947.LF.388_-_Courtauld_Gallery.jpg. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression; applicable ShareAlike terms retained. · Public domain

The palm and gridiron identify Lawrence without depicting the violence associated with his martyrdom. His upright figure gathers the attributes into one readable presentation, while angels appear above. The image offers recognition through signs held or displayed beside a person; the story need not be enacted to remain available.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P.1947.LF.388

14 / 20

Saint Sebastian in a Rocky Landscape with Saints Jerome, Anthony Abbot and Christopher

Marco Zoppo

c. 1475–1478 · The Courtauld Gallery



Marco Zoppo. Saint Sebastian in a Rocky Landscape with Saints Jerome, Anthony Abbot and Christopher. Image credit: Sailko. Wikimedia Commons. CC BY-SA 3.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. Additional source attribution: Sailko; Required attribution: I, Sailko. File page: https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Marco_zoppo,_san_sebastiano,_1475-78_ca._2.JPG · CC BY-SA 3.0

Sebastian's exposed body is larger and more prominent than the other saints distributed through the rocky setting. His raised arm extends its twisting contour. The shared landscape connects a devotional assembly rather than one simultaneous historical incident, allowing differences of scale to indicate how the figures should be attended to.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: P.1978.PG.489

15 / 20

A Mandarin Drake

Eugène Delacroix

c. 1825 · Watercolour on paper · The Courtauld Gallery



Eugène Delacroix. A Mandarin drake. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/eugene-delacroix/a-mandarin-drake · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The plain paper gives the bird’s profile and folded plumage room to remain distinct. Colour divides parts of its construction without dissolving the drake into an ornamental pattern. This close study rewards following how differently marked feathers still belong to one body, rather than assigning the whole image a generalised vividness.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Boats at Martigues

Raoul Dufy

1908 · The Courtauld Gallery



Raoul Dufy. Boats at Martigues. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The hulls crowd together as red, green and blue shapes, with masts rising through the harbour above them. Reflections add another set of adjoining marks. Dufy keeps the boats identifiable while making their relation on the painted surface unusually assertive. The eye can follow vessels and interlocking colour without choosing only one.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

The Colossus of Rhodes

Maarten van Heemskerck

1570 · The Courtauld Gallery



Maarten van Heemskerck. Colossus of Rhodes. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/maerten-van-heemskerck/colossus-of-rhodes-1570 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The giant's legs span a harbour whose ships and people supply measures of its proposed size. Detailed architecture makes the reconstruction persuasive, but does not turn it into an eyewitness record. Heemskerck's image gives a lost wonder a visible form; the confidence of its drawing should be distinguished from certainty about the ancient monument.

Object source · Open artwork

18 / 20

Cupid and Psyche

Joshua Reynolds

1789 · The Courtauld Gallery



Joshua Reynolds. Cupid and Psyche. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Psyche’s raised light makes the sleeping Cupid available to her gaze. His body remains unguarded while her leaning posture and lifted arm describe an active search. The mythological encounter turns on unequal awareness, with illumination doing more than modelling flesh: it permits one person to see another who cannot return the look.

Object source · Open artwork

19 / 20

Holy Family with the Infant Saint John and Saint Elizabeth

Benvenuto Tisi

1520 · The Courtauld Gallery



Benvenuto Tisi. Holy Family with the Infant Saint John and Saint Elizabeth. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The curtain makes an opening above a tightly assembled group. Inclining adults and children at different heights remain linked through touch rather than arranged as separate frontal figures. Garofalo uses the narrow setting to keep the devotional encounter intimate, while the parted fabric gives that closeness a visible frame.

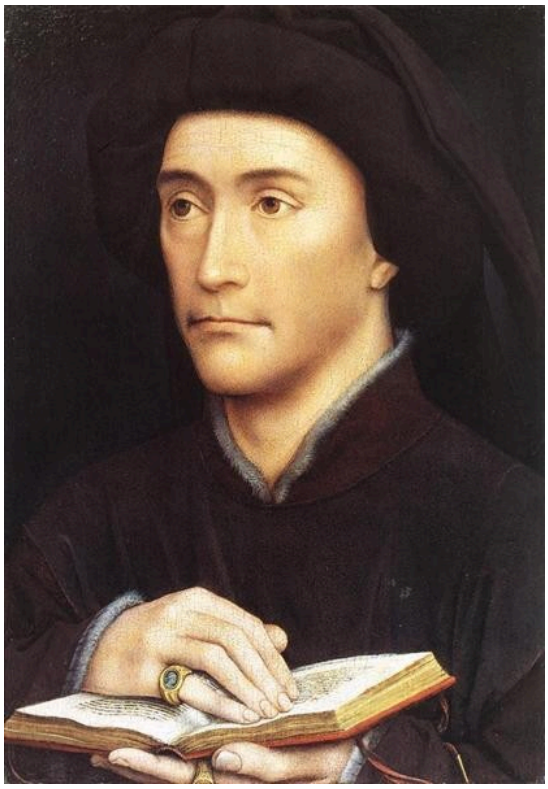
Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Man Holding a Book

Rogier van der Weyden

1440-1449 · The Courtauld Gallery



Rogier van der Weyden. Man holding book. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The open book creates a pale foreground around the hands, while dark headwear and background concentrate the face. Reading supplies an activity without requiring a dramatic gesture. The portrait joins a particular likeness to the careful disposition of fingers and pages, giving stillness enough structure to remain specific.

Object source · Open artwork

Separate access from certainty

Manet’s mirror, Reynolds’s raised light and Bruegel’s small travelling group each determine what a spectator can see. Heemskerck’s reconstruction asks a further question: what does seeing allow us to know? Use the collection records for object details, and current gallery information for display availability; the sequence here is not a confirmed hanging.

Further reading

Impressionism: A Centenary Exhibition

Anne Dayez, Michel Hoog and Charles S. Moffett · Read online or download · English

The exhibition catalogue places Manet, Seurat and the painters around them within the debates of nineteenth-century art. Its illustrations support comparisons of public entertainment, private interiors and the changing marks used to describe them.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12